It is particularly requested that the names of the Gentlemen to be presented be *very distinctly written* on the Presentation Cards delivered to the Lord Chamberlain at the Levee, in order that there may be no difficulty in announcing them to His Royal Highness.

The State Apartments will be open for the reception of Company coming to Court at half-past one o'clock. LATHOM,

Lord Chamberlain.

Lord Chamberlain's Office, St. James's Palace, April 29, 1897.

NOTICE is hereby given, that Her Royal Highness The Princess of Wales will, by command of The Queen, hold a Drawing Room at Buckingham Palace, on behalf of Her Majesty, on Tuesday, the 18th May next, at three o'clock.

REGULATIONS TO BE OBSERVED AT THE QUEEN'S DRAWING ROOM.

By Her Majesty's Command,

The Ladies who propose to attend Her Majesty's Drawing Room are requested to bring with them to the Drawing Room two large cards, with their names *clearly written* thereon, one to be left with The Queen's Page in Attendance, and the other to be delivered to the Lord Chamberlain, who will announce the name to The Queen.

PRESENTATIONS.

The privilege of making presentations to The Queen at a Drawing Room is restricted to those Ladies who have themselves been previously presented to Her Majesty, and who are themselves present at the Drawing Room.

Under such circumstances a Lady has the privilege of presenting one Lady only at a Drawing Room in addition to her Daughters or Daughters-in-law.

This restriction does not apply to Ladies who, from official position or other circumstances, are specially privileged to make presentations to Her Majesty.

The Lady who proposes to present another must send in writing the name of such Lady to the Lord Chamberlain's Office, not later than *two days* previous to the Drawing Room, in order that the Lord Chamberlain may submit the name to Her Majesty, when, if it be approved, presentation cards will be forwarded.

Printed Forms for this purpose can be obtained at the Lord Chamberlain's Office.

It is particularly requested that the names of the Lady to be presented be *very distinctly written* on the presentation cards to be delivered to the Lord Chamberlain at the Drawing Room, in order that there may be no difficulty in announcing them to The Queen.

It is not expected that Gentlemen will present themselves at the Drawing Room, except in attendance on the Ladies of their families.

Any Gentleman who under these circumstances should desire to be presented to The Queen will observe the same regulations as are in force for Her Majesty's Levees.

The State Apartments will be open for the reception of Company coming to Court at two o'clock. LATHOM,

Lord Chamberlain.

Admiralty, May 7, 1897.

DESPATCHES, of which the following are copies, have been received from Rear-Admiral Harry H. Rawson, C.B., Commander-in-Chief on the Cape of Good Hope and West Coast of Africa Station, reporting operations against the King of Benin, and the capture of Benin City.

H.M.S. "St. George," at Forcados,
27th February, 1897.

Sir,

With reference to the arrangements I had made for a naval expedition against Benin City, in compliance with your telegram No. 9 of the 15th idem; and in view of the absence of any reliable information in regard to Benin, and of the necessity for immediate action, I considered it advisable to organise the expedition on the largest scale which the force at my disposal would permit.

2. Between the dates of my reaching Brass (30th ultimo), and of the arrival there of Mr. R. D. R. Moor, C.M.G., H.M. Commissioner and Consul-General for the Niger Coast Protectorate (3rd instant), I obtained much valuable information about Benin, which had been collected by Captain H. L. Gallwey, D.S.O. (H.M. Acting Commissioner and Consul-General.)

The fact of the position of Benin City having never been astronomically fixed, however, nor the country and creeks surveyed, necessitated my having to rely in a great measure upon reports from the only three natives who had ever visited the place.

3. The few white men, who have ever been to Benin, appear to have taken the route from Gwato; because, I am given to understand, the king has never permitted them to approach the city by any other road; but as it is well known that there is no water on that route; and as there was every reason to believe, from the reports of natives, that there was a continuation of the Ologi Creek (fresh water) at a short distance to the eastward of the city; I decided, after carefully considering the question, to form a base at Warrigi; widen the existing path from thence to Ceri, and then, if practicable, cut my way through the forest along the left bank of the Ologi Creek to within striking distance of Benin, thus insuring a good supply of water throughout the march.

4. Seeing, however, that I could obtain no reliable information as to the nature of the country through which I proposed to march, until I could place a force at Ceri, my alternative plan was to cross the creek at Ceri by a wire suspension bridge which I had prepared to throw across (the creek here being fifty yards wide and fourteen feet deep, with a strong current); to establish a depôt at Ologbo Beach; and then cut my way through the forest from thence to Benin, should there be no suitable road.

5. In this decision H.M. Consul-General and Lieut.-Colonel B. M. Hamilton concurred; and I also arranged, after consultation with them, that, about the date of the expedition landing at Warrigi, two separate forces should be detached:—

One, under Captain M. P. O'Callaghan, of H.M.S. "Philomel," to destroy Gwato; then advance to Eggbini; hold that place until the 14th instant; and then occupy and hold Ikoro.

The other, under Captain T. MacGill, of H.M.S. "Phœbe," to stockade and hold a position four miles above Sapoba.

By despatching these separate expeditions, it was considered that two objects would be attained—

(1.) To divert the enemy's attention from the intended direction of the attack on the city; and

(2.) To prevent the escape of fugitives to the eastward or westward into, what are now, peaceful districts.

6. Whilst awaiting the arrival of the transport "Malacca" (on the 8th instant), all carriers procurable (2160) were collected and sent to Warrigi; where a base was established, and stores for the expedition landed.

H.M. ships "Philomel," "Phœbe," "Barrosa," "Widgeon," "Magpie," and "Alecto" were sent up the Benin River, and the "St. George," "Theseus," and "Forte" anchored off the mouth of the Forcados River.

I also hired four light draught steamers from Lagos for service as transports in the river and creeks.

7. The Niger Coast Protectorate troops were, in the meantime, moved up to Warrigi, with a party of native road-makers, to complete the road to Ceri, and to form a camp there for the whole force; thus enabling the bluejackets and marines to march to Ceri the same day they were to land at Warrigi.

This work was satisfactorily completed by the 8th instant; consequently, when the "Malacca" arrived off Forcados, on the evening of that day, the expedition was ready to start.

8. I decided, after consultation with the Consul-General, to reduce the landing party from H.M. ships to 700 fighting men,—a force thought to be rather larger than actually necessary to meet the enemy, but considered desirable with a view to the future moral effect throughout the whole Niger Coast Protectorate.

9. On the 9th instant, the landing parties from H.M. ships "St. George," "Theseus," and "Forte," and the Royal Marines from the transport "Malacca," were conveyed in the four hired steamers, viâ Forcados and Nana Creek, to Warrigi, where they arrived the next afternoon.

10. The following day I landed at Warrigi, and marched with the whole force to Ceri.

11. Lieutenant-Colonel B. M. Hamilton, with the Niger Coast Protectorate troops, had before my arrival at Ceri, ascertained that any advance from that place, along either bank of the Ologi Creek, was impracticable owing to swamps.

I therefore had to adopt the alternative route mentioned in paragraph 4.

12. On the morning of the 12th instant I commenced to move the force from Ceri, up the Ologi Creek in boats, to Ologbo landing place (a distance of about two miles, and on the opposite bank of the creek), Lieutenant-Colonel Hamilton being in command of the advance guard, composed of two companies of Houssas and one company of bluejackets from H.M.S. "Theseus," under Lieutenant H. A. S. Fyler, of that ship.

Here the enemy made their first stand; but, after a short engagement, were driven up a forest path beyond the village of Ologbo (about a mile to the northward of the landing place), which was then occupied.*

13. On the 14th instant, the whole force, carriers, and supplies, having been moved to Ologbo landing place, the scouts and advance guard (then composed of the Houssas and marines from H.M.S. "Theseus," under Captain G. L. Beaumont, R.M.L.I., of that ship), advanced from Ologbo village along a path leading in the direction of Benin City.

After proceeding about four miles, the scouts reported the enemy in front.

From this point there was a running fight, our men firing volleys and advancing at the double,* the enemy making a stand whenever there was sufficient cover, and replying briskly to our volleys from flanking paths, which they had cut parallel to the main path, until "Cross Roads" (a position four miles to the northward of Ologbo) was reached and occupied, this place being apparently the enemy's main camp.

14. As I had received reports from the detached forces at Gwato and Sapoba of the enemy's determined stand there, and reinforcements having been requested at both places; also, seeing that the enemy had not only shown an intention of opposing our advance throughout the whole march on the city; but that they had proved themselves much better acquainted with the method of bush fighting than was generally supposed; I deemed it advisable to call up the remainder of the force as originally organised (see paragraph 1), especially in view of the long line of communication with the base, which would have to be protected.

15. On the 10th instant, Captain M. P. O'Callaghan, with a force from the "Philomel," "Barrosa," and "Widgeon," occupied and destroyed Gilli-Gilli and Gwato.

He was unopposed at the former place.

At the latter he found the town deserted, and saw nothing of the enemy until half the place had been burnt, when a heavy fire was opened upon him from the neighbouring forest,* which it took nearly an hour to silence. Captain M. P. O'Callaghan then destroyed the remainder of the town; and re-embarked his force with a view to carrying out his orders to advance to Eggbini and Ikoro on the arrival of the reinforcements which he considered desirable in view of the enemy having collected in considerable numbers near Gwato.

On receiving this communication, however, I decided that the object would, under the circumstances, be better attained by directing Captain O'Callaghan, after being reinforced, to re-occupy and hold Gwato, instead of advancing to Eggbini and Ikoro.

This was accordingly done on the 16th instant, without opposition, and steps were at once taken to fortify the camp, and to clear away the bush surrounding it. Shortly afterwards, however, the enemy opened fire from the forest;* which was continued at intervals until the evening, and repeated several times during the 17th and 18th, when the enemy finally retreated.

16. On the 11th instant, the other force, under Captain MacGill (with men drawn from the "Phœbe," "Alecto," and "Magpie"), which had proceeded up the Jamieson River to Sapoba,—built a stockade four miles to the northward of that place, where the main road from Benin branches in two directions.

Here the party employed in building the stockade were attacked from the neighbouring forest, and a sharp engagement took place before the enemy were driven away.*

This force was again attacked on the morning of the 20th instant, but the enemy were repulsed after a short engagement.*

17. On the 15th instant Lieutenant-Colonel Hamilton, with the scouts and advanced guard,

* See list of casualties, Enclosure No. 1.

* See list of casualties, Enclosure No. 1.

left "Cross Roads" camp, and advanced along the Benin path.

After he had proceeded about four miles, the enemy attacked both flanks, and continued firing at intervals from the dense forest until their camp at Agagi (a mile further on) was reached. The enemy then retreated, and the place was occupied without further opposition.*

18. It had been anticipated that there would be water at Agagi, suitable, at any rate, for the carriers; but as all the wells there were found to be dry, and each house provided with chatties, it appeared that the natives had been obliged to store their water.

19. The question of the water supply for both fighting force and carriers became, therefore, a very serious one—since none could be found between Agagi and Ologbo Beach (10 miles), and it was improbable that there would be any between Agagi and Benin (12 miles), which subsequently proved to be the case.

20. To keep up a sufficient supply of water for the force and carriers which I had intended to take on to Benin would have entailed great delay, which, at that stage of the march, I considered it a matter of the greatest importance to avoid, if possible.

I therefore decided to push on at once by forced marches to Benin, with a flying column, taking three days' water (at the rate of two quarts for each officer or man, and one quart for carriers per day), also four days' provisions, with the necessary ammunition, &c., &c.—the remainder of the force and supplies being left at "Cross Roads" camp and Ologbo Beach.

21. On the 16th instant, the flying column, composed as follows, was assembled at Agagi:—

40—Scouts, under Lieutenant S. E. Erskine H.M.S. "Philomel," and Mr. Turner, of the Niger Coast Protectorate.

240—Niger Coast Protectorate troops, with two 7-pr. guns and a Maxim, under Lieutenant-Colonel B. M. Hamilton.

60—A company of seamen from H.M.S. "St. George," with a Maxim, under Lieutenant Llewellyn Griffiths, of that ship.

10—Rocket and demolition party.

60—Marines, with a Maxim, from the transport "Malacca," under Captain G. T. Byrne, R.M.L.I.

60—Marines from H.M.S. "Theseus," with a Maxim, under Captain Beaumont, R.M.L.I., of that ship.

The whole of the Royal Marines being under the command of Major T. H. de M. Roche, R.M.L.I., of H.M.S. "St. George."

60—Bluejackets, with a Maxim, from H.M.S. "Theseus."

The Protectorate Troops being short of officers, I lent Sub-Lieutenant J. A. Gregory, of H.M.S. "Theseus" and Sub-Lieutenant B. O. F. Phibbs of H.M.S. "St. George," for duty with them.

My personal and general staff consisted of:—

Captain G. Le C. Egerton, of H.M.S. "St. George," Chief of the Staff.

Lieutenant W. N. England, Flag Lieutenant, A.D.C. and Camp Master.

Commander R. H. S. Bacon, H.M.S. "Theseus," Chief of Intelligence Department, who was also placed in the advance guard with Lieutenant-Colonel Hamilton.

Lieutenant Stuart Nicholson, of H.M.S. "St. George," who was in charge of the arrangements for the water supply.

Lieutenant R. G. Gregory, of H.M.S. "St. George," Staff Officer.

The carriers were in charge of Lieutenant E. R. Pears of H.M.S. "Forte," and Lieutenant W. H. Cowan of H.M.S. "Barrosa."

The medical officers were:—

Staff-Surgeon J. Mc. C. Martin, of H.M.S. "Forte,"

Staff-Surgeon E. R. Dimsey, of H.M.S. "Phœbe," and

Surgeon C. J. Fyfe, of H.M.S. "St. George."

Mr. R. D. R. Moor, C.M.G., H.M. Commissioner and Consul-General, and Captain Child, of the Niger Coast Protectorate Yacht "Ivy," accompanied the headquarters.

Lieutenant-Colonel B. M. Hamilton was placed in command of the advance guard; and Captain C. Campbell, C.B., of H.M.S. "Theseus," in command of the rear guard. The marines from the "Malacca" forming a reserve under my own immediate orders.

22. Leaving Agagi at 6.30 A.M. on the 17th instant; the flying column cut itself free from the base and advanced to Awoka; arriving there at 2 P.M., after having been harassed the whole way by constant attacks from the bush; the advance being necessarily very slow.*

That night the camp was fired into.*

23. On the 18th instant, the column left Awoka at 6.30 A.M.; the only alteration in the formation of the column being that the marines of H.M.S. "Theseus," (who up to this point had been with the advance guard), now changed positions with the "St. George's" A Company.

During the whole of this day, the head and both flanks of the column were constantly attacked.*

At 1 P.M., a stockade was come across; commanding a narrow causeway with a deep ravine on each side, and defended by a few guns. These were silenced, and the stockaded path cleared with guncotton.

About 300 yards further on, as the enemy appeared to be in considerable force in front, a halt was made, and the 7-prs. and rockets were fired with extreme elevation over the supposed strongest position of the enemy, and where Benin City was thought to be.

About a mile beyond this we suddenly emerged from the bush path into a causeway about fifty yards wide, running at right angles to our path, with dense bush on each side. Here a very heavy fire was opened upon our men; and the enemy were, for the first time, actually seen—a body of them attempting to charge the head of our column as we advanced out of the narrow bush path. A Maxim, however, and a few volleys from the "St. George's" A Company soon drove them back into the bush. There were also some heavy guns fired from the causeway which surrounded the King's compound.

An advance was at once made along the road to the King's palace, under a rather heavy fire from both sides, which, at such close quarters, did us considerable damage.*

The King's compound was then occupied; the killed and wounded brought in; the carrier column and rear guard marched up from the narrow path—where they had been halted until the enemy had been cleared out, and the men's water bottles filled; leaving us with only one quart of water per man as a reserve.

The heat along this causeway was terrific; and the men (who had been marching from 6.30 a.m. to 2.30 p.m.) were much exhausted, but I am proud to report that not a single officer or man fell out from his place after leaving "Cross Roads."

* See list of casualties, Enclosure No. 1.

* See list of casualties, Enclosure No. 1.

24. All tents and coverings having been left behind, the best arrangements possible were made to shelter the men for the night.

25. At daylight on the 19th instant, two-thirds of the force, with all the carriers, were sent off as a water party; the remainder of the force defending the camp.

The water party returned in about three hours, having found a very good running stream about two miles distant.

26. In the afternoon a strong force was marched out, and destroyed Chief Ijuma's compound.

27. Orders had been sent to Ologbo Beach for provisions and ammunition to be forwarded on to Benin.

Also for the "St. George's" steam pinnace and two Jakri canoes to try and find their way by the Ologi Creek to the city, with a view of conveying the wounded down by water. The command of this party was given to Lieutenant T. F. Michell, of H.M.S. "St. George," whose report is attached (Enclosure No. 7.)

28. I had intended returning with the whole force on the 20th instant; but as the Protectorate troops were short of ammunition, and had no stores up with them, I deemed it necesary to place them in a defensible position before I left the city. I therefore remained until the morning of the 22nd.

29. The 20th and 21st were occupied in preparing a defensive position for the Protectorate Force, and in getting water for our march down.

30. Two parties were sent out to destroy the Queen-Mother's and Chief Ichudi's compounds. Also the sacrificial and crucifixion trees, and the whole of the Ju Ju houses.

31. The King, with all the inhabitants, having disappeared, I was unable to carry out their Lordships' wish that he should be captured.

32. We heard, from some liberated slaves, that no white prisoners had been brought to Benin City; but all the effects of the late ill-fated expedition were found in the King's palace.

33. The Protectorate ammunition and stores arrived on the night of the 20th instant.

34. At 4 p.m. on the 21st instant, a fire, started by carriers, spread in a few minutes over the whole town; and by the promptitude of Captain Campbell, of H.M.S. "Theseus," the wounded were got out while the temporary hospital was actually on fire.

Some arms, ammunition, and most of our provisions, were burnt. Fortunately, however, the "Forte's" company, under Lieutenant F. R. Harrold, arrived within an hour with a fresh supply; and the whole white force was thus enabled to start for the base on the morning of the 22nd instant.

35. I left, for the use of the Protectorate force, two Maxims and one rocket tube, with the necessary ammunition; also the Martini-Henry rifles which had been issued to the scouts.

I also transferred to them two of the four days' provisions brought up by the "Forte's" company.

36. The base at Warrigi was reached on the 24th, after a trying return journey for the wounded; who, however, were safely brought down.

37. The whole of the force were re-embarked by the evening of the 27th instant.

38. The Sapoba force, under Captain MacGill, re-embarked and returned to Warrigi on the 25th.

39. The Gwato force, under Captain O'Callaghan, re-embarked in their ships on the 27th instant.

40. As on the march up, so on the march down, not a single officer or man of the flying column fell out.

41. I much regret to have to report the following casualties during the expedition—as detailed in Enclosure No. 1:—

(*a.*) Killed in action:—
2 officers,
8 men { 5 whites, 3 blacks.

(*b.*) Wounded in action:
6 officers (including 1 native officer),
44 men { 22 whites, 22 blacks.

(*c.*) Deaths from the effects of climate:—
1 officer,
4 men (whites).

(*d.*) Deaths from accident:—
1 man (white),
1 man (black).

(*e.*) 72 cases of smallpox occurred amongst the native carriers.

42. In an expedition like this has been, where unusual hardships have been endured from excessive heat, forced marches, shortness of water, and even of provisions—to say nothing of the whole march having been harassed by an unseen enemy—I consider that every officer and man under my command has merited the highest praise; and, although I am aware that only a comparative few can hope to be rewarded at present, I feel it my duty to place on record the names of many others also, who have done such good work that I trust their Lordships will, in any case, bear them in mind for future reward.

I, therefore, wish to bring to their Lordships' notice the following officers individually, who have shown themselves deserving of special recognition:—

My personal staff, who accompanied me on the expedition, viz.:—

Mr. William H. Rowe, my Secretary;

Lieutenant William N. England, Flag Lieutenant (who also carried out the duties of camp master*);

Mr. Herbert S. Measham, Assistant Paymaster (Secretary's Clerk);

Mr. Thomas W. S. Seath, Assistant Clerk (Secretary's Clerk);

From all of whom I have received the greatest assistance during a time of very severe pressure.†

Captain George Le C. Egerton, of H.M.S. "St. George," who, as chief of the staff, organised and carried out his duties with such zeal and energy that it is not too much to say that the whole success of the expedition has resulted from the work he has done.

Captain M. P. O'Callaghan, of H.M.S. "Philomel," and Captain T. MacGill, of H.M.S. "Phœbe," each had command of a separate force—the former at Gwato, the latter at Sapoba—and engaged the enemy entirely independently of the main force. The positions they held on either flank took off the attention of large numbers of the enemy, who would otherwise have been opposed to the flying column.

Captain Charles Campbell, C.B., of H.M.S. "Theseus," commanded the rear guard at the attack on the city; and by his prompt action at the fire which broke out on the 21st instant, saved the lives of the wounded.‡

* When my office staff were sick, Lieutenant England also gave his services to help.—H. H. R.

† My staff, though often sick themselves, worked on, and Mr. Rowe's services have been invaluable.—H. H. R

‡Was indefatigable, and always ready for work.—H.H.R

Captain R. F. O. Foote, of H.M.S. "Forte," had command of the 2nd Division, and did good work; being left behind to clear out the several bases.

Commander J. Startin, of H.M.S. "Barrosa," was in command of the road cutters, and worked indefatigably to clear the way to Ceri. He was then sent round to Gwato to join Captain O'Callaghan's force, by whom he is also very favourably mentioned. (See Enclosure, No. 3.)

Commander W. Stokes-Rees, of H.M.S. "St. George," was in charge of the Carrier Column and Commissariat; and, by his energetic and continuous work, enabled the force to be moved with promptitude.

Commander R. H. S. Bacon, of H.M.S. "Theseus," did most excellent work as Chief of the Intelligence Department; and managed to collect much valuable information regarding the route to Benin City, from what appeared to be a sterile source. His plans and reports will be found in Enclosure No. 2. He was in the advance guard the whole time with Lieutenant-Colonel Hamilton.

Commander H. H. Torlesse of H.M.S. "St. George," was in command at the base.

On Lieutenant Stuart Nicholson, of H.M.S. "St. George," who had charge of the water supply, the whole safety of the expedition depended; and I would strongly call their Lordships' attention to this officer.

Lieutenant E. R. Pears, of H.M.S. "Forte," and Lieutenant W. H. Cowan, of H.M.S. "Barrosa," were in charge of the carriers. Their work was beyond all praise; and the way they managed to organise, out of chaos, the carriers from different tribes, was most creditable.

Lieutenant S. E. Erskine, of H.M.S. "Philomel," was in command of the scouts, and not only had the post of danger throughout, but did his work extremely well.

Lieutenant Llewellyn Griffiths, of H.M.S. "St. George," who was in command of the "St. George's" Company, was leading during the last day; and, with the Houssas, and marines from the "Malacca," bore the brunt of the fighting.

Lieutenant H. A. S. Fyler, of H.M.S. "Theseus," had command of the company from that ship, at the attack on Ologbo Beach.

Lieutenant H. V. W. Elliott, of H.M.S. "Magpie," and Lieutenant F. W. Kennedy, of H.M.S. "Phœbe," are both mentioned in Captain MacGill's despatch (Enclosure No. 4).

Lieutenant M. R. Hill, of H.M.S. "Barrosa," and Lieutenant E. J. Newman, R.N.R., of H.M.S. "Philomel," are both mentioned in Captain O'Callaghan's despatch (Enclosure No. 3).

Lieutenant F. R. Harrold, of H.M.S. "Forte," brought the company of that ship, with stores, up to Benin City, at a most opportune moment.

I would specially recommend Sub-Lieutenant B. O. F. Phibbs, of H.M.S. "St. George," Sub-Lieutenant J. A. Gregory, of H.M.S. "Theseus," and Sub-Lieutenant E. O. Gladstone, of H.M.S. "Alecto." The two former did excellent service with the Houssas; and the latter was invaluable at the base.

Major T. H. Roche, R.M.L.I., of H.M.S. "St. George," was in command of the Royal Marines.

Captain G. T. Byrne, R.M.L.I., in command of the marines from the "Malacca," was very severely wounded at the taking of the city.*

Captain G. L. Beaumont, R.M.L.I., was in command of the marines of H.M.S. "Theseus."*

Fleet-Surgeon M. Fitzgerald, organised the Medical Department, and rendered me every assistance.

Staff-Surgeons E. R. Dimsey, of H.M.S. "Phœbe," and J. McC. Martin, of H.M.S. "Forte," were with the flying column, and upon them fell the whole work of attending the wounded and bringing them down.

Surgeon R. T. A. Levinge, of H.M.S. "Alecto," is specially mentioned in Captain MacGill's despatch (Enclosure No. 4).

Surgeon C. S. Facey, of H.M.S. "Widgeon," is mentioned in Captain O'Callaghan's despatch (Enclosure No. 3).†

Surgeon F. H. A. Clayton, of H.M.S. "St. George," although ill himself, worked most assiduously with the sick.

Mr. Wm. Johnston, Torpedo Gunner, of H.M.S. "Philomel," is specially mentioned by Lieutenant-Colonel Hamilton for his services with the advance guard; and I wish to bring his name to their Lordships' particular notice.

Mr. G. Jeans, Gunner, Mr. T. G. Mobbs, Boatswain, and Mr. S. J. Lacey, Carpenter—all of H.M.S. "St. George," did excellent work. Mr. Jeans with the "St. George's" Company at the taking of Benin; Mr. Mobbs, at Ologbo Beach; and Mr. Lacey with the pioneer party.

Mr. Robt. Brown, Torpedo Gunner of H.M.S. "Penelope," is mentioned in Captain O'Callaghan's despatch (Enclosure No. 3).

Mr. Wm. Trew, Fleet-Paymaster, of H.M.S. "St. George," was stationed at Warrigi, as Chief Accountant Officer of the Expedition.

Mr. T. J. Stovin, Staff-Paymaster of H.M.S. "Philomel," was commissariat officer on shore, and did exceedingly good work.

Mr. W. Morshead, Assistant-Paymaster of H.M.S. "Theseus," accompanied the flying column to Benin City as commissariat officer. I cannot speak too highly of this officer's services, and desire to bring his name to their Lordships' special notice.

Mr. F. H. Gerty, Assistant-Paymaster of H.M.S. "Phœbe," is highly commended for the energetic manner in which he assisted in commissariat and other duties at the base.

Mr. F. Main, Engineer of H.M.S. "St. George," did exceedingly good work with the pioneer and bridge party.

I wish to draw their Lordships' attention to the conspicuous gallantry displayed by Richard J. Tiddy, Petty Officer, 1st Class (Official number 137123) of H.M.S. "Alecto," as reported by Captain MacGill in his despatch (Enclosure No. 4).

Also to the exemplary behaviour whilst working the Maxim gun of James D. B. Death, Able Seaman (Official number 169123) of H.M.S. "Theseus," as reported by Lieutenant-Colonel Hamilton in his despatch (Enclosure No. 5).

Sergeant Charles Burrill, R.M.L.I., Ch./3357 of H.M.S. "Philomel," is highly mentioned in Captain O'Callaghan's despatch (Enclosure No. 3).

Lieutenant-Colonel B. M. Hamilton has, during the expedition, rendered me every assistance,—not only by his advice, which has always been sound, but in command of the advance guard he has had to carry out most of the fighting. His arrangements were judicious, and the slight loss we sustained I consider due to his

* After Captain Byrne was wounded, Lieutenant Diblie and Lieutenant Robinson commanded sections of the marines.—H. H. R.

* Is also mentioned by Dr. Martin in assisting the wounded.—H. H. R.

† Staff-Surgeon Gipps and all the Medical Officers of the Expedition have been most indefatigable in their attention to the sick and wounded.—H. H. R.

On the 12th instant, it being found impossible to bridge the creek at Ologbo owing to swamp on both banks, the native troops were transported to Ologbo, a distance of 2 miles, by launch and surf-boats. A landing under Maxim fire from launch being effected, the village was eventually taken. During this operation, Captain L. C. Koe, of Niger Protectorate force, was severely wounded in arm, and three native troops slightly. With Admiral Rawson I visited Ologbo, returning for night to Ciri.

On the 13th instant, as a large force was reported collecting in Sapoba direction, reinforcements were made for Jamieson River column, and the 1st division of main column with Head-Quarters Staff crossed from Ciri to Ologbo. There was an alarm in the camp this night which turned out to be of little consequence.

On the 14th instant, the 2nd division of main column crossed from Ciri to Ologbo, taking the place of the native troops who had started under Colonel Hamilton at daylight to form a camp at some cross roads 5 miles distant. The inclosed report of Colonel Hamilton gives details of this operation, during which a Company Sergeant-Major and two privates of native troops were severely wounded. During the day there were discovered in the bush around Ologbo thirty-four of the enemy's dead.

On the 15th instant the native troops moved on to the village of Ogage, 4 miles distant from cross roads, losing one private killed and one carrier, and one scout severely wounded, on the march. The 1st division with Head-Quarters Staff took up position at cross roads camp.

On the 16th instant at 2 A.M. Lieutenant Turner arrived from Ogage, and from his reports the difficulties of water supply in getting up the entire column were fully appreciated. It was therefore decided that the 2nd division should only move up as far as the cross roads camp. The 1st division with Head-Quarters Staff moved up and joined native troops at Ogage, finding on arrival that a scout attached to reconnoitring party had just been killed.

From Ogage camp, the native troops, Head-Quarters Staff, and 1st division moved on to Awoko, a distance of 7 miles, on the 17th instant. On the march three camps of the enemy and one village were taken, a running fight being kept up the entire journey. One scout was wounded, and while making camp at Awoko a shot was fired into it, wounding one seaman slightly and a carrier severely; the latter died next day.

The camp at Awoko was left at daylight to make the journey of 8 miles to Benin city—the marching distance from Ologbo to the city being estimated at 24 miles.

During the entire day, the column was in contact with the enemy, and casualties were continually occurring. About 1½ miles from the city, two fresh human sacrifices were met with in the path, the unfortunate beings having had their arms tied behind their backs and been gagged with pieces of stick. They had then been cut from the chest down and across the stomach and their entrails were hanging out. This no doubt was Ju Ju sacrifice to prevent the white man entering the town. About 1 mile from main road to town a stockade and rifle pit were met with, the former being destroyed with gun-cotton and out of the latter the enemy were quickly driven. Three small guns were found in the stockade. A short distance further on an open space was reached, and from this a fire from rocket-tube and 7-prs. was opened on the city. This was subsequently found to have been well directed, for the rockets and effects of shell were found in city. A quick advance was then made, but heavy fire encountered just before the bush path debouched into broad main road leading to city. It took some little time to dislodge the enemy, which being effected, the column deployed into a broad road with the city about 1,000 yards distance. Up to this the advance was in skirmishing order under continuous fire from bush on right flank.

The final effort of the enemy was the discharge of two cannon from large open space in front of what were afterwards found to be some of the King's sacrificial Ju Ju compounds. The troops with a cheer charged the last 200 yards into the city, which was actually taken at about 2 o'clock. The men were much exhausted, the day having been exceptionally hot as several subsequent ones were, and water supply short.

The entire casualties of the expedition, as at present reported, are nine killed and forty-two wounded, made up as follows:—

Killed.

Lieutenant-Commander Pritchard.
Naval Surgeon Fyfe.
1 chief petty officer.
1 seaman.
2 marines.
1 sergeant, Protectorate force.
1 scout.
1 carrier.

Severely Wounded.

Captain Byrne, R.M.L.I.
,, L. C. Koe, Protectorate force.
1 naval warrant officer.
1 ,, petty officer.
4 marines.
3 seamen.
9 Protectorate force (N.C.O.'s and privates).
8 carriers.
3 scouts.
1 interpreter.

Slightly Wounded.

Captain O'Callaghan, Her Majesty ship "Philomel."
3 marines.
4 seamen.
2 Protectorate force.

There may be further slight casualties from the Gwato and Jamieson River columns of which I have no knowledge.

The foregoing does not include deaths from sunstroke and exhaustion.

The individual particulars of casualties among Imperial troops I have not given, as they are supplied by Rear-Admiral Rawson to the Admiralty and I have not the complete details.

The city presented the most appalling sight, particulary around the King's quarters, from which four large main roads lead to the compounds of the bigger Chiefs, the city being very scattered.

Sacrificial trees in the open spaces still held the corpses of the latest victims—seven in all were counted—and on every path a freshly-sacrificed corpse was found lying, apparently placed there to prevent pursuit. One large open space, 200 to 300 yards in length was strewn with human bones and bodies in all stages of decomposition.

Within the walls the sight was, if possible, more terrible. Seven large sacrifice compounds were found enclosed by walls 14 to 16 feet high, each 2 to 3 acres in extent; against the end wall in each, under a roof, was raised a daïs with an

earthen (clay) sacrificial altar about 50 feet long close against the wall on which were placed the gods to whom sacrifice was made—mostly being carved ivory tusks, standing upright, mounted at base, in hideously-constructed brass heads. In front of each ivory god was a small earthen mound on which the victim's forehead would apparently be placed. The altars were covered with streams of dried human blood, and the stench was too frightful.

It would seem that the populace sat around in these huge compounds while the Ju Ju priests performed the sacrifices for their edification. In the various sacrifice compounds were found open pits filled with human bodies giving forth most trying odours. The first night several cases of fainting and sickness occurred owing to the stench, which was equally bad everywhere.

In one of the pits, partially under other bodies, was found a victim, still living, who, being rescued, turned out to be a servant of Mr. Gordon's, one of the members of Mr. Phillips' ill-fated expedition. At the doors and gates of houses and compounds were stinking goats and fowls, sacrificed apparently to prevent the white man entering therein.

The foregoing is but a feeble attempt to describe the house of this most terrible city, which, after five days' continuous fatigue working with about 1,000 natives, still presents most appalling and frightful sights. In the outlying parts of the city the same sights are met, and the annual expenditure of human life in sacrifice must have been enormous.

Most of the wells were also found filled with human bodies. Goats and fowls were also used for sacrifice, and for the latter elaborate altars with two bronze cocks on each were found erected.

On the 19th three Jekris of the ill-fated expedition came in from bush terribly mutilated, and stated that on the approach of the troops all the remaining members who had been brought to the town were killed. The Ju Ju trees and altars were this day destroyed, and the outlying compounds of the big Chiefs commenced to be burnt, this work being completed the following day. An old Benin woman who was captured was sent out to the people telling them to come in. Six Accra men captured in the Mahin country rubber collecting during the last few months, came in from bush heavily ironed. The effects of the late Mr. Phillips and his party were found in the King's palaver-house almost intact, but unfortunately they were subsequently destroyed by fire.

A fire, unfortunate only in that we were unprepared for it, broke out about 4 P.M. on the 21st instant and destroyed the King's and all surrounding quarters, leaving us only open camp; but the cleansing effects of it compensated fully for the destruction of shelter and loss of baggage and provisions which occurred. Fortunately, just as the force was again settling down, a carrier column under escort arrived with provisions.

The entire naval brigade left under Admiral Rawson on morning of the 22nd instant, and the native troops, under Lieutenant-Colonel Hamilton, moved into the camp selected and partially prepared. There are 270 troops in all, with a complement of 350 carriers; but with escorts and a small flying column out opening roads, there will only be about 200 in camp as a rule.

On the afternoon of this day four messengers arrived from the King, begging and asking if he could come with his Chiefs to palaver. I sent message back that they could come if they wished, but I guaranteed nothing, but that hostilities should be suspended till Friday, 26th, to enable them to come. In any case, nothing could possibly be done up to that date or later, as the camp cannot be earlier completed and cleansed.

Yesterday, 23rd instant, two natives came in, rather with a view to spying, to see what line the King could take, one suggesting it being a question of paying for the massacre. They were sent away with a reassuring but evasive answer, and I am in hopes that some of the Chiefs at least may come in, in which case it will only be a matter of time to get hold of the King and his Ju Ju men.

This morning a flying column left to open the Gwato route, which messengers who were sent down on the 20th instant and returned yesterday report is now safe.

This brings the history of the operations up to date, and I now propose remaining here with entire force until the natives come in, and an attempt can be made to deal with the affair of the massacre by native palaver, country custom being very strict in demanding an eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth.

It is imperative that a most severe lesson be given the Kings, Chiefs, and Ju Ju men of all surrounding countries, that white men cannot be killed with impunity, and that human sacrifices, with the oppression of the weak and poor, must cease.

All buildings on this site, saturated as it is with the blood of human victims, will be levelled to the ground, and no building of any description will ever again be allowed to be erected thereon. If a town is again built it must be nearer the water, which is now three miles distant.

The success of the operations speaks more for the conduct of them than anything that I can say; but having been with Rear-Admiral Rawson and the Head-Quarters Staff from the commencement of active work, I should mention the unsparing and untiring energy displayed by both the Admiral and Flag-Captain Egerton. The work has been continuous, day and night, and all that care, forethought, and judgment could do to insure success and spare the men as much as possible has certainly been done. From time to time, as fresh difficulties were encountered, it was found necessary to vary and reorganize the original plans, but this was done with judgment and dispatch, so that no delay has on any occasion been thereby caused. Looking back, it will be found that the first news of the disaster was not communicated in London or at the Cape until the 10th January, and on the 18th February the party, having come, roughly, 5,000 miles, from three different directions, entered Benin city. There was little time for preparations, except such as could be ordered by telegraph; but there is no direction in which the arrangements have failed, though the expenditure has probably been unavoidably somewhat heavy. The immediate object of the expedition—the taking of Benin city—having been successfully attained, I would respectfully submit that Rear-Admiral Rawson and his staff are entitled to full recognition of their services, which will, no doubt, be duly accorded them by Her Majesty's Government. The permanent result of the operations are yet to be attained, and to this task the attention of the officials of the Protectorate is now earnestly turned. The punishment of the individuals responsible for the massacre is of these the first,

for it will be an object-lesson in civilization for the poor and weak to see the rich and strong punished for misdeeds perpetrated by their orders. Civilization with protection to life and property has then to be introduced, and the country opened up to trade—this must be the work of years.

Inclosed I forward copy of letter* addressed by me to Rear-Admiral Rawson on completion of the operations, and before his departure. With all requests therein the Admiral has complied.

Referring to copies of letter and enclosure from Lieutenant-Colonel Hamilton, inclosed herein, I should fully wish to indorse the recommendations regarding the officers mentioned, and I would request that representations be made in the proper quarter that their services may receive due recognition.

Major Landon, Captain Walker, and Lieutenant O'Shee are special service officers, and, no doubt, if recommended by your Lordship, the War Office will duly reward their services.

Captain N. Burrows, Niger Coast Protectorate Force, is a seconded officer, being a Lieutenant in the Loyal North Lancashire Regiment; also Captain C. H. P. Carter, Niger Coast Protectorate Force, is a seconded officer from Black Watch, and Captain Crauford Cockburn, from Queen's Bays. The War Office might also be able to reward these officers regimentally in some way; if not, I would suggest that their services may receive some other form of recognition.

Dr. Allman has been Principal Medical Officer of this Protectorate since 1891, and has organized the medical and sanitary staff most efficiently, and carried out his duties with care and judgment. His services are, I consider, deserving of recognition.

Major Searle is a most efficient officer in the Niger Coast Protectorate Force, but not connected in any way with Her Majesty's Imperial Forces. His services on this occasion should assist his advancement in the Protectorate.

Lieutenant Daniels, Niger Coast Protectorate Force, native officer. I should recommend a pecuniary reward in this case, not exceeding 15*l.*

With regard to the members of Her Majesty's navy mentioned in the despatch, Rear-Admiral Rawson will, no doubt, recommend their advancement, but I would request that these cases be also represented to the Admiralty through the Foreign Office.

I should wish particularly to bring to your Lordship's notice the tact, judgment, and foresight brought to bear by Lieutenant-Colonel Hamilton in the duty intrusted to him, that of taking command of the force of the Protectorate. He from the first established a thorough understanding and friendly relations with the officers of the force, and maintained a strict discipline with all ranks, so that there has been no word of complaint nor any feeling of discontent.

Having some experience of the class of warfare carried on during these operations—that of bush fighting—I venture the opinion that the force has been most ably and effectually handled, and for this the highest praise is due to Lieutenant-Colonel Hamilton and the officers under his command. The difficulties of transport and water supply have been very great, and they have been as successively overcome as the immediate object of the expedition—the taking of Benin city—has been accomplished.

Considering the duration of the operations—seven days—and the class of warfare, the casualties cannot be considered heavy, and this is undoubtedly owing to the judgment displayed in the handling of the immediate front of the column by Lieutenant-Colonel Hamilton, where the brunt of the fighting on the march was borne. I would request that the services of Lieutenant-Colonel Hamilton receive their well-merited recognition.

I should further bring to your Lordship's notice the work done by Mr. Vice-Consul Gallwey, D.S.O., prior to my arrival. He had concentrated the Protectorate forces at Brass, and effectually carried out telegraphic instructions I sent him from Grand Canary. He had also rendered considerable assistance in the Intelligence Department to Rear-Admiral Rawson. Since my arrival it has been necessary, owing to the failure of one officer, to attach himself to the force under Colonel Hamilton, where he has loyally carried out the work of a company officer, asd has, at the same time, assisted me in political work when required. His services are worthy of recognition.

I would strenuously urge that the services of all officers and men engaged in the operations be recognized by the issue of a medal and clasp, which, I submit, is most thoroughly deserved. An arduous and perilous duty has been carried out with enthusiasm and disregard of danger and privation by all ranks under most trying circumstances of climate and position of the enemy, who were, I may say, always unseen.

There is but one other point I should bring to notice, and that is the prompt and willing assistance rendered me by the Governors of Sierra Leone and the Gold Coast, Colonel Cardew and Sir William Maxwell. I found it advisable to telegraph from Grand Canary for carriers and equipment to both places, and, on arrival, found that the greatest care and trouble had been taken to comply with my requests, and everything supplied has been of the greatest service. I wish, therefore, here to place it on record that the assistance rendered has to some extent contributed to the success of the expedition.

I am, &c.,
(Signed) R. MOOR.

Inclosure 2 *in No.* 1.

Lieutenant-Colonel Hamilton to Consul-General Moor.

Benin City,
Sir, February 23, 1897.

I BEG to forward you a copy of the report* of the operations (12th to 18th instant) which I have addressed to the Admiral and Commander-in-chief in chief command of the Benin expeditionary force.

In addition to the officers therein mentioned, I should like to bring to your notice the excellent scouting work done by Captain Cockburn, Niger Coast Protectorate Force, before the crossing of the Ologbo Creek on the 12th instant. He has throughout shown great pluck and indefatigable energy.

Dr. Allman, the Principal Medical Officer to the force, is also deserving of commendation. His organizing power with the carriers under him and energy have been invaluable, and since our arrival here I have made him Provost-Marshal.

I further wish to mention favourably to you

* Already included in Rear-Admiral Rawson's despatches. (See Enclosure No. 6.)

* Already included in Rear-Admiral Rawson's despatches. (See Enclosure No. 5.)